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Philosophy of Politics:
National socialism in Germany: race, state,
totalitarianism

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National Socialism in Germany: Race, State, Totalitarianism

- From Nazi movement to political regime
- Race as a principle of political organization
- State, party and Führer
- Propaganda, terror and social control
- Central question: *How did National Socialism attempt to reorganize state and society around a racial worldview?*

From Ideology to Regime

- Hitler became chancellor on 30 January 1933
- The Nazis initially entered government within existing constitutional institutions
- Those institutions were rapidly transformed and dismantled
- Political pluralism gave way to dictatorship
- Nazi ideology became increasingly embedded in law, administration and public institutions

The Destruction of Weimar Democracy

- Emergency powers weakened constitutional protections
- Political opponents were arrested and intimidated
- The Enabling Act transferred extensive legislative power to Hitler's government
- Opposition parties were subsequently eliminated
- By July 1933 Germany had become a one-party state

Gleichschaltung

- Usually translated as “coordination” or “bringing into line”
- Institutions were reorganized under Nazi political control
- Federal structures lost substantial autonomy
- Independent organizations were dissolved, transformed or incorporated
- The objective was the elimination of autonomous centers of political and social power

Beyond the Liberal State

- Liberal constitutionalism limits and divides political power
- Nazism rejected institutional pluralism as fragmentation
- Rights could not stand independently against racial-national objectives
- Political authority was increasingly concentrated around the Führer
- *The state was no longer conceived as neutral between competing political interests*

What Was the Nazi State?

- Nazi Germany was not simply a conventional centralized bureaucracy
- Party and state institutions frequently overlapped
- Traditional ministries continued to operate
- New Nazi organizations acquired competing responsibilities
- Personal authority increasingly connected this fragmented institutional system

Party and State

- The Nazi Party did not simply disappear into the state
- Party organizations developed alongside government institutions
- SS, SA and other organizations acquired important political functions
- Jurisdictions frequently overlapped
- Nazi governance combined ideological unity with institutional competition

The Führer Principle

- *Führerprinzip* organized authority hierarchically
- Subordinates were expected to obey superiors
- Political authority ultimately converged on Hitler
- Leadership replaced parliamentary deliberation as the central political principle
- Personal command became increasingly important within the legal and administrative order

Hitler and Political Authority

- After President Hindenburg's death in August 1934, Hitler combined the functions of head of state and government
- His position was presented as deriving from his relationship with the German *Volk*
- Political legitimacy became personalized
- Institutions increasingly operated through reference to the Führer's authority
- The regime cultivated an extensive leadership cult

“Working Towards the Führer”

- Officials did not always require detailed instructions from Hitler
- They could anticipate what they believed his political objectives to be
- Institutional competition encouraged increasingly ambitious initiatives
- Hitler's broad ideological goals could therefore produce decentralized radicalization
- Personal dictatorship did not require detailed personal management of every policy

Carl Schmitt: Sovereignty

- Schmitt defines the sovereign through the power to decide on the exception
- Extraordinary situations reveal where ultimate political authority lies
- Legal order cannot completely determine the conditions of its own survival
- Sovereignty therefore contains an irreducible element of decision
- *Who decides when normal law no longer applies?*

The State of Exception

- Constitutional government normally operates through established legal rules
- Emergency politics permits extraordinary measures
- Weimar Germany already contained constitutional emergency provisions
- The Nazi regime used emergency powers to dismantle constitutional restraints
- The exception increasingly became a mechanism for establishing a new political order

Schmitt and Political Unity

- Schmitt criticized liberal parliamentary pluralism
- Political communities require decisions about membership and political unity
- The political cannot be reduced to economics or private morality
- His friend–enemy distinction emphasizes the possibility of existential collective conflict
- Nazi racial politics supplied a radically different, biological criterion for defining membership and enemies

Race as Political Principle

- Nazi ideology divided humanity into supposedly distinct racial groups
- These groups were arranged hierarchically
- Political institutions were expected to protect the racial community
- Citizenship became connected to ancestry
- *Race moved from ideological belief into state classification and law*

From Citizen to Racial Subject

- Liberal citizenship begins from legal membership
- Nazi political membership increasingly depended on racial classification
- Rights differed according to assigned racial status
- The state claimed authority to determine ancestry and belonging
- Political exclusion could therefore be administered bureaucratically

The Nuremberg Laws

- Adopted in September 1935
- The Reich Citizenship Law distinguished citizens from other state subjects
- The Law for the Protection of German Blood and German Honor prohibited specified relationships between Jews and those classified as “German or related blood”
- Later regulations formalized racial classifications
- Antisemitism was thereby embedded directly in law

Bureaucratizing Race

- Racial ideology required administrative categories
- Officials examined ancestry and family records
- Legal definitions determined who counted as Jewish under Nazi law
- Bureaucracy transformed ideological categories into administrative classifications
- *Radical ideology could operate through ordinary documents, offices and procedures*

The *Volksgemeinschaft*

- Nazi propaganda promised a unified “people's community”
- Class and party divisions were supposedly transcended
- Membership was defined racially
- Inclusion therefore depended upon exclusion
- The imagined unity of the community was inseparable from defining those who did not belong

Inclusion and Exclusion

- “Aryan” Germans were encouraged to identify with a common national community
- Political rituals reinforced belonging
- Welfare and social organizations could strengthen integration
- Racially and politically defined outsiders faced escalating exclusion
- Nazi community-building therefore had both integrative and persecutory dimensions

Antisemitism and the Regime

- Antisemitism was central rather than peripheral to Nazi ideology
- Jews were portrayed as a racial and existential enemy
- Discrimination intensified through legislation and administrative measures
- Economic and social exclusion expanded
- Nazi racial policy became progressively more radical

From Discrimination to Persecution

- Jewish participation in public life was increasingly restricted
- Employment and professional opportunities were curtailed
- Property and economic activity came under growing pressure
- Social separation was increasingly institutionalized
- The process unfolded through cumulative radicalization rather than one single measure

Kristallnacht

- 9–10 November 1938
- Synagogues and Jewish businesses were attacked across Germany and Austria
- Jews were killed and tens of thousands of Jewish men were sent to concentration camps
- State and party institutions were implicated in the violence
- The pogrom marked a major escalation in anti-Jewish persecution

Race and Expansion

- Nazi racial ideology extended beyond Germany's existing borders
- *Lebensraum* connected territorial expansion with racial objectives
- Eastern Europe became central to Nazi imperial ambitions
- Conquest was accompanied by plans for demographic reorganization
- Foreign policy and racial policy increasingly became inseparable

War as Racial Politics

- The invasion of Poland in 1939 initiated World War II in Europe
- The invasion of the Soviet Union in 1941 had an explicitly ideological and racial dimension
- Nazi authorities targeted Jews, Soviet political officials and other groups
- Occupation involved exploitation, displacement and mass killing
- War created conditions for further radicalization of racial policy

The Holocaust

- Nazi Germany and its collaborators systematically murdered approximately six million European Jews
- Mass shootings became a major method of killing in occupied Soviet territories
- Deportation networks transported victims across occupied Europe
- Killing centers became central instruments of mass murder
- Genocide combined ideology, bureaucracy, technology and organized state violence

Beyond the Jewish Victims

- Nazi racial and political persecution targeted multiple groups
- Roma and Sinti were subjected to genocidal persecution
- Disabled people were murdered through the so-called “euthanasia” program
- Soviet prisoners of war suffered mass death
- Political opponents, homosexual men and others were also persecuted under different policies and rationales

The Concentration Camp System

- Concentration camps existed from the beginning of the Nazi regime
- Initially they were used extensively against political opponents
- The camp system expanded and changed over time
- Forced labor became increasingly important during the war
- Concentration camps and extermination centers performed different, though sometimes overlapping, functions

Terror and Political Control

- The Gestapo investigated political and ideological enemies
- The SS became a central institution of racial and security policy
- Concentration camps created spaces of extraordinary coercion
- Courts and police institutions were transformed by Nazi political objectives
- Terror operated alongside bureaucracy and social participation

Propaganda

- Joseph Goebbels headed the Ministry of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda
- Radio, film, newspapers and public spectacle were politically coordinated
- Hitler's leadership cult was continually reinforced
- Propaganda promoted racial and national categories
- Communication aimed to shape the boundaries of legitimate political reality

Propaganda and *Mein Kampf*

- Hitler had already emphasized propaganda in *Mein Kampf*
- Political messages should be simplified
- Repetition was considered essential
- Emotional identification was prioritized
- Propaganda was conceived as an instrument for organizing mass political perception

Controlling Culture and Knowledge

- Universities and cultural institutions were politically transformed
- Books and artistic works could be censored or excluded
- Racial categories affected academic and professional life
- Education was reorganized around ideological objectives
- The regime sought influence over how society understood itself

Youth and Socialization

- Nazi organizations sought to shape political identity from childhood
- Hitler Youth and League of German Girls expanded dramatically
- Education emphasized racial ideology and national duty
- Physical discipline and collective belonging were promoted
- Totalitarian ambition extended beyond obedience toward *formation of political subjects*

Hannah Arendt: Totalitarianism

- Arendt distinguishes totalitarian domination from conventional dictatorship
- Her analysis emphasizes ideology and terror
- Totalitarianism seeks deeper transformation than merely controlling government
- It aims at comprehensive domination of human beings
- Nazi Germany and Stalinist Soviet rule are her principal cases

Arendt: The Totalitarian Movement

- Totalitarian movements emerge within modern mass society
- Traditional social and political attachments can weaken
- Atomized individuals become politically significant
- Propaganda organizes apparently comprehensive explanations of reality
- The movement offers belonging within an ideologically structured world

Atomization

- Arendt emphasizes social isolation and political loneliness
- Individuals become disconnected from durable institutions and associations
- Mass society differs from organized class politics
- Totalitarian movements can mobilize people who lack stable political attachments
- *Domination becomes easier when individuals cannot act together independently*

Ideology

- Arendt treats ideology as more than a collection of political beliefs
- Ideology claims to reveal the logic underlying historical reality
- Events are interpreted through one supposedly universal explanatory principle
- In Nazism, race provides such a principle
- Ideological consistency can become more important than contradictory empirical evidence

Terror

- Terror eliminates actual political opposition
- But Arendt argues that totalitarian terror extends further
- Individuals can be targeted because of assigned objective categories
- Guilt becomes less important than classification
- Terror attempts to make ideological assumptions politically real

Totalitarianism and the State

- Totalitarian rule does not necessarily produce simple administrative order
- Party and state structures can overlap and compete
- Authority can remain deliberately unstable
- Ideological objectives drive institutions beyond conventional legal limits
- Totalitarian power seeks domination rather than merely efficient government

Race, State and Totalitarianism

- **Race:** determines the imagined boundaries and hierarchy of the political community
- **State:** converts ideological categories into law and administration
- **Führer:** concentrates and personalizes ultimate political authority
- **Ideology and propaganda:** structure political interpretation
- **Terror:** removes opposition and enforces racial-political transformation

The National Socialist Question

- Hitler: *What happens when politics is interpreted as racial struggle?*
- Schmitt: *What happens when sovereign decision overrides normal legal constraints?*
- Nazi state: *What happens when law itself becomes an instrument of racial classification?*
- Arendt: *How can ideology and terror transform dictatorship into totalitarian domination?*
- Fundamental question: *What happens to political life when the state no longer protects a common legal order but instead organizes society around an existential distinction between those who belong and those designated as enemies?*